Lesson 33: APA Style: Its Levels, References and Citations

English Stage 4 (Psychology) · Unit 5: Writing and Presenting Research in APA Style

Adapted from Research Methods in Psychology (4th American edition) by Rajiv S. Jhangiani, I-Chant A. Chiang, Carrie Cuttler and Dana C. Leighton (CC BY-NC-SA 4.0): 11.1 Prelude to Presenting Your Research; 11.2 American Psychological Association (APA) Style; exercises from 11.5 Presenting Your Research (Summary).

In this lesson

Research is complete only when it is shared, and psychologists share it in APA style, a genre with three levels. You will see how APA style reflects the values of science, practise formal and bias-free English, and format references and citations by the current (7th) edition of the *Publication Manual*.

Learning goals

After this lesson you should be able to:

- Define APA style and describe its three levels, with an example of each.
- Explain how features of APA style reflect scientific values.
- Rewrite informal or biased wording in formal, straightforward and bias-free English.
- Format references to articles, books and chapters, and cite them in the text, by 7th-edition rules.

Key language

Term or phrase	Meaning	Example
APA style	a set of guidelines for writing in psychology and related fields	not MLA or AP style
Publication Manual	the APA book that contains all the guidelines of APA style	7th edition, 2020
organization	the most general level of APA style: the organization of a research article	the fixed order of sections
high-level style	the second-most general level: guidelines for the clear expression of ideas	formal, straightforward writing
low-level style	the most specific level: rules on spelling, grammar, references, citations, tables and figures	numerals for 10 and above
reference	the formatted publication information about a cited work, listed at the end	Kashdan, T., & Biswas-Diener, R. (2014). ...
reference citation	a mention of a reference in the text: the authors' last names and the year	(Burger, 2008)

Term or phrase	Meaning	Example
hanging indent	the first line of a reference is not indented, the following lines are	every reference
DOI	digital object identifier: a permanent link to an article on the Internet	https://doi.org/10.1037/...
to hedge	to make a conclusion tentative	"The results *suggest* that ..."
it could be argued that	introduces a claim cautiously	"it could be argued that ... you are not really engaged in science"
when in doubt	if you are not sure	"when in doubt, find an appropriate reference to cite"

Rules and explanations

The ideas

Why publish (11.1). Science is a social and cumulative process; others can build on your research only when it joins the literature.

What APA style is. Its main purpose is to facilitate scientific communication by promoting clarity of expression and standardizing the organization and content of articles. It is a *genre*, not "good writing" in general: a literary analysis belongs in MLA style, a newspaper article in AP (Associated Press) style, an empirical research report in APA style.

Level	What it covers	Examples
1. Organization	the structure of an article	Title page, Abstract, Introduction, Method, Results, Discussion, References
2. High-level style	the clear expression of ideas	formal: no slang, contractions or humor; straightforward: short, direct sentences, technical terms only where they help ("immersed their hands in ice water", not "were subjected to a pain-inducement apparatus"); bias-free
3. Low-level style	specific rules	spelling, grammar, references and citations, numbers, tables, figures

APA style and scientific values (Madigan et al., 1995): few direct quotations (phenomena are objective, not tied to one researcher's words); criticism of the work, not the person (science seeks general conclusions); many citations (research is a large-scale collaboration); fixed sections (an ideal approach to research); hedged conclusions (knowledge is tentative).

Bias-free language, for accuracy as well as respect: (1) put the person first: *people diagnosed with schizophrenia*, not *schizophrenics*; (2) be specific: *Chinese Americans*, not *Asian Americans*, if all are Chinese American; (3) do not objectify participants: "The students completed the questionnaire", not "The subjects were administered the questionnaire". Also *sexual orientation*, not *sexual preference*; *firefighters*, not *firemen*.

Common low-level errors (Onwuegbuzie et al., 2010) include words for numbers 10 and above, a missing hyphen in "role-playing technique", *since* meaning *because*, no comma before *and* in a series of three, an abbreviation not spelled out first, and "&" in the running text or *and* inside parentheses.

References. All works cited, and only those, on a new page headed "References", alphabetical by first author, double-spaced, with hanging indents. The formats below are 7th-edition; the book's examples (6th edition) also give a location before the publisher ("New York, NY: Guilford Press") and write "doi:10.1037/...".

- Journal article: Author, A. A., Author, B. B., & Author, C. C. (year). Title of article. *Title of Journal, volume*(issue), pp–pp. https://doi.org/xx.xxxx
- Book: Author, A. A. (year). *Title of book*. Publisher.
- Chapter: Author, A. A. (year). Title of chapter. In A. A. Editor & B. B. Editor (Eds.), *Title of book* (pp. xxx–xxx). Publisher.
- Authors in the order on the work, last names and initials, "&" before the last author (even with two). Article and book titles in sentence case (capitals only for the first word, proper nouns and proper adjectives such as *Freudian*, and the first word of a subtitle); journal titles in title case. Italics for book titles and for the journal title and volume, not the issue. Editors' initials come first; "(Ed.)" for one editor.

Citations. Cite other researchers' phenomena, theories, hypotheses, specific methods, and facts that are not common knowledge; not widely shared concepts (*t* test) or very broad statements ("Working memory plays a role in many daily activities.").

	Narrative	Parenthetical
Example	Burger (2008) conducted a replication of Milgram's (1963) original obedience study.	People can be surprisingly obedient to authority figures (Burger, 2008; Milgram, 1963).
Two authors	Adair and Vohra (2003)	(Adair & Vohra, 2003)
Year	may be left out after the first citation in a paragraph	always
Best for	emphasizing the researcher; one study in detail	a general idea; several sources (alphabetical, with semicolons)

Treat authors as people: "Milgram's (1963) study", not "Milgram (1963)". *Et al.* (Latin *et alia*, "and others") stands for the other authors. The book's rule: two authors, both names every time; three to five, all names the first time, then *et al.*; six or more, *et al.* every time. No comma before *et al.*; a period only after *al.*

> **APA 7th edition** (the book follows the 6th edition, 2010)
>
> - Three or more authors: *et al.* from the first citation: Mehl et al. (2007).
> - DOIs are URLs: https://doi.org/10.1037/0003-066X.58.1.15 (no "doi:" and no "Retrieved from").
> - No publisher location: "... Guilford Press."

- "References" is bold and centered; a reference lists up to 20 authors.
- The 7th edition (2020) has more than 400 pages, not "nearly 300".

Language focus

1. Researcher or idea in focus? Narrative citations put the researcher first, usually with a past-tense reporting verb: "Burger (2008) *conducted* ..."; "Mehl ... (2007) *found* essentially no difference ...". Parenthetical citations put the idea first, often in the present tense: "People *can be* surprisingly obedient ... (Burger, 2008; Milgram, 1963)"; "Recent evidence *suggests* that men and women *are* similarly talkative (...)".

2. Formal and hedged. Full forms (*do not*), plain words, active sentences with participants as the subject ("The students completed the questionnaire"), and hedged conclusions ("The results *suggest* that ...").

Note for Arabic speakers

- Arabic script has no capital letters, so check capitals in every reference: sentence case for article and book titles, title case for journal titles.
- Long sentences joined with "and" are common in formal Arabic prose; APA style prefers short, direct sentences.

Practice

1. Reading questions

1. Why could it be argued that unpublished research is "not really" science (11.1)?
2. What is the primary purpose of APA style?
3. Why is APA style called a "genre"?
4. Name the two themes of high-level style.
5. Which scientific value lies behind (a) hedged conclusions, (b) many citations?
6. Why is *sexual orientation* better than *sexual preference*?
7. Which need a citation? (a) yearly cell phone–related accidents; (b) "Working memory plays a role in many daily activities."; (c) the meaning of *t* test; (d) another researcher's questionnaire.
8. When must a narrative citation include the year, and a parenthetical one?

2. Book exercises (from 11.5)

1. "Practice: Find and correct the errors in the following fictional APA-style references and citations."
    - (a) Walters, F. T., and DeLeon, M. (2010). Relationship Between Intrinsic Motivation and Accuracy of Academic Self-Evaluations Among High School Students. Educational Psychology Quarterly, 23, 234–256.
    - (b) Moore, Lilia S. (2007). Ethics in survey research. In M. Williams & P. L. Lee (eds.), Ethical Issues in Psychology (pp. 120–156), Boston, Psychological Research Press.

    - (c) Vang, C., Dumont, L. S., and Prescott, M. P. found that left-handed people have a stronger preference for abstract art than right-handed people (2006).
    - (d) This result has been replicated several times (Williamson, 1998; Pentecost & Garcia, 2006; Armbruster, 2011)

2. "Practice: Find a description of a research study in a popular magazine, newspaper, blog, or website. Then identify five specific differences between how that description is written and how it would be written in APA style."

3. Language exercise

1. Rewrite in bias-free, straightforward style: (a) The subjects were administered the questionnaire. (b) Schizophrenics were recruited from two clinics. (c) The firemen completed a stress questionnaire.
2. Update the book's references to Adair and Vohra (2003) and Lilienfeld and Lynn (2003) in 11.2 to the 7th edition.
3. Make these citations narrative, by 7th-edition rules: (a) Recent evidence suggests that men and women are similarly talkative (Mehl, Vazire, Ramirez-Esparza, Slatcher, & Pennebaker, 2007). (b) There is a strong positive correlation between the number of daily hassles and the number of symptoms people experience (Kanner et al., 1981).

Speak with your tutor

- "Let me explain the three levels of APA style with an example of each. Correct my content and my English."
- "In PSYC 110 Lecture 15 (Morality, Chapter 4), Professor Bloom says Milgram's study has been replicated with many subjects. Check my two sentences about Milgram (1963) and Burger (2008): one with narrative and one with parenthetical citations."
- "Give me works with one, two, three and six authors; I will cite each one in 7th-edition style."

Writing task

Your research project: citations and references. For your proposal on sleep and memory in university students (or your own topic), write:

1. A reference list of at least five sources from your literature search (Lesson 04), at least three of them journal articles. Copy every detail from the article's first page or its database record (for example in PsycINFO); never guess a detail.
2. A paragraph of 150 to 200 words for your literature review (Lesson 34) that cites at least three sources: at least one narrative citation, one parenthetical citation, and one set of parentheses with two or more sources.

Self-editing checklist:

- Every citation has a reference, and every reference is cited.
- "References" starts a new page; entries are alphabetical, double-spaced, with hanging indents.

- Authors appear as last names and initials, with "&" before the last author.
- Article and book titles are in sentence case; journal titles in title case and italics, with the volume.
- DOIs are https://doi.org/ URLs; books have no publisher location.
- In the text: *and* in narrative citations, "&" in parentheses, *et al.* for three or more authors.
- Findings have reporting verbs; conclusions are hedged; there are no contractions or biased labels.

Paste your draft into the chat and ask your tutor for feedback. Then rewrite it.

Watch online

- APA Style, free 7th-edition guidance (the book's apastyle.org now leads here): https://apastyle.apa.org
- Purdue Online Writing Lab, APA guide (new address of the book's link): https://owl.purdue.edu/owl/research_and_citation/apa_style/apa_formatting_and_style_guide/general_format.html

Answer key

1. Reading questions

1. Science is a social, cumulative collaboration; others can learn from and build on research only when it is added to the literature.
2. To facilitate scientific communication by promoting clarity of expression and standardizing the organization and content of articles.
3. It suits one writing task, presenting psychological research; it is not "good writing" in general (MLA for literary analysis, AP for news).
4. Formal and straightforward.
5. (a) Scientific knowledge is tentative and open to revision. (b) Research is a large-scale collaboration.
6. People do not generally experience their orientation as a "preference", nor is it as easily changeable as the term suggests: a matter of accuracy, not only of avoiding offense.
7. (a) and (d): a fact that is not common knowledge, and a specific method. (b) is too broad to argue with; (c) is a widely shared concept.
8. Narrative: the first time the work is cited in a paragraph. Parenthetical: every time.

2. Book exercises (book's rules; 7th edition in brackets)

1. Corrected:
    - (a) Walters, F. T., & DeLeon, M. (2010). Relationship between intrinsic motivation and accuracy of academic self-evaluations among high school students. *Educational Psychology Quarterly, 23*, 234–256. ("&"; sentence case; italics. [Add the issue and DOI only if they exist.])
    - (b) Moore, L. S. (2007). Ethics in survey research. In M. Williams & P. L. Lee (Eds.), *Ethical issues in psychology* (pp. 120–156). Boston, MA: Psychological Research Press. (Initials; "Eds."; italic, sentence-case book title; a period after the pages; "City, State:" before the publisher, as in the book's examples. [No location.])
    - (c) Vang, Dumont, and Prescott (2006) found that left-handed people have a stronger preference for abstract art than right-handed people. (No initials; year after the names. [Vang et al. (2006) found ...])
    - (d) This result has been replicated several times (Armbruster, 2011; Pentecost & Garcia, 2006; Williamson, 1998). (Alphabetical order; final period.)
2. (example answer) A news report may have a catchy headline, contractions or jokes, direct quotations from the researcher, no citations or reference list, an unhedged claim ("Sleep makes you smarter"), and no method or statistics. Any five clear differences are correct.

3. Language exercise

1. (a) The students completed the questionnaire. (b) People diagnosed with schizophrenia were recruited from two clinics. (c) The firefighters completed a stress questionnaire.

2. Adair, J. G., & Vohra, N. (2003). The explosion of knowledge, references, and citations: Psychology's unique response to a crisis. *American Psychologist, 58*(1), 15–23. https://doi.org/10.1037/0003-066X.58.1.15
    - Lilienfeld, S. O., & Lynn, S. J. (2003). Dissociative identity disorder: Multiple personalities, multiple controversies. In S. O. Lilienfeld, S. J. Lynn, & J. M. Lohr (Eds.), *Science and pseudoscience in clinical psychology* (pp. 109–142). Guilford Press.
3. (a) Mehl et al. (2007) found that men and women were similarly talkative. (b) Kanner et al. (1981) reported a strong positive correlation between the number of daily hassles and the number of symptoms people experience.

My notes